

ON APOLOGIES: THE TESTAMENT OF BISHOP LAKSHMAN WICKREMASINGHE

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The apology extended by the Prime Minister to the Tamils evicted from their lodgings in Colombo on 7th June 2007 has evoked mixed reactions. Some of his Ministerial colleagues have questioned the need for an apology. Many others, Tamils and non-Tamils, have warmly welcomed it. A retired Sinhalese Major General has publicly thanked and congratulated the Prime Minister and strongly endorsed the apology. This particular eviction is related to our understanding of human rights and the concept of exclusive homelands. There is also the broader question of who, if any, should apologise when some wrong has been done. Apologies must emerge spontaneously from the heart and cannot be prescribed. However, few would deny the positive consequences of an apology or dispute the need for the wrongdoer to apologise for any wrong done. But is it ever necessary to extend an apology for the actions of others? For example, if some children do harm to others, would it not be appropriate for the parents, teachers etc, even if they had no hand in that wrong, to apologise? By extension, would it not be appropriate, on the principle of command responsibility, for leaders or persons in authority to apologise for the wrongdoing of officials and subordinates, even if that action was not authorised?

Further, what if there is no vertical line of command connecting the leaders to the offenders but only linkages arising from common identities, in cases where that wrong was committed in the name of one or more of those identities? For example, should someone who is blameless apologise for acts of religious bigotry committed by others of the same faith, or of ethnic cleansing committed by those of the same ethnicity, or of caste oppression by those of the same caste, or of unprofessional conduct by those of the same profession? Was the apology of the Sinhalese Major General for the eviction of the Tamils from the lodges warranted? Similarly, are apologies warranted from Tamils who were unconnected with the massacre of Muslim worshippers at Kattankudi and Eravur or of Sinhalese at Arantalawa or the attack on the Dalada Maligawa?

When Gandhi carried out his non-violent Satyagraha campaigns, he expected the Satyagrahis to submit to any violence inflicted on them without retaliating in kind. Whenever some of his followers resorted to violence, Gandhi not only called off the campaign but also apologised, even if such retaliatory violence was a response to greater violence inflicted on Satyagrahis. Did Gandhi need to apologise? Closer home we have the example of Bishop Lakshman Wickremasinghe. He was in the UK under treatment for a very serious heart condition when the 1983 pogrom occurred. Disregarding his doctor's orders he promptly returned to Sri Lanka in response to the national crisis. He came to Jaffna to meet the displaced. His visit lifted the spirits not only of those displaced but also those of others concerned, such as myself (I was then District Secretary / Government Agent, Jaffna). Twenty four years on, the memories of that visit have not faded, nor his message staled. He then went on to

other districts in the North and East to meet the displaced. What he saw and heard affected him deeply and, by the time he reached his ancestral home in Colombo and his office in Kurunegala his health condition was precarious. Then, as Bishop of Kurunegala, he wrote a profound and deeply moving pastoral letter in October 1983, and died soon afterwards. In that pastoral letter he confessed, "I was among those who tried hard and failed [to find a solution to the ethnic conflict]". A central feature of the Bishop's pastoral letter was an apology as a Sinhalese addressed to Tamil victims of the pogrom. The Bishop first analysed, one by one, from a Sinhalese perspective, the familiar reasons widely put forward to explain the violence directed against the Tamils. Did the many acts of violence by armed Tamil militants warrant violent retaliation against other Tamils? The Bishop's response is that we need to rise above "tribal vengeance" and "tribal morality". Further, did the Sinhalese have undue disadvantages and suffer discrimination at the hands of the British? Did the Tamils continue to enjoy undue advantages and privileges? Even if the pogrom was unjustified, did it help to bring about a more equitable balance in opportunities as between the Sinhalese and Tamil populations? Rejecting such arguments, the Bishop proclaims that, "We [must be] ashamed as Sinhalese for the moral crime other Sinhalese have committed."

The Bishop goes on to explore the need for an apology to the Tamil victims. Since he had no hand in the riots or in the build up to the riots, and was in no position to stop it, was an apology due from him? He cites the pride the Sinhalese today take in the Sinhala heritage, including Sinhala Bhuddism. Did they contribute to that heritage? Is not their pride based merely on their sense of ethnic and national identity with those responsible for developing that civilisation? If that sense of identity warranted pride in those achievements, then should it also not require apologising to the Tamil victims for the terrible actions in July 1983 of those claiming to act on behalf of the Sinhalese? The Bishop proceeds to make an unqualified apology as a Sinhalese to the Tamil victims of the pogrom of July 1983. Bishop Lakshman Wickremasinghe's pastoral letter, written in the wake of the pogrom of July 1983, focuses on that crisis. But the message of the Bishop is equally relevant to all of us. Victims and perpetrators of communal violence are found among all sections of the population; confessions and apologies are due from each of us. An apology made under pressure is of limited value, but a spontaneous apology could be an irresistible first step towards reconciliation. His pastoral letter, formulated while yet "in the midst of our worst national crisis since the beginning of our independence", is not a detached scholarly theological offering but an anguished message from the heart of a thoughtful and deeply caring Bishop. That message from one of the great Sri Lankans of our time is a classic that needs to be read and re-read carefully and thoughtfully by all of us. ■

REVOLUTIONARY TRAILS: EDMUND SAMARAKKODY: A POLITICAL PROFILE

Perera, T. 2006, *Revolutionary Trails: Edmund Samarakkody: A Political Profile*, 222 pages. Colombo: Social Scientists' Association. Price Rs. 400.

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Beginning in the early 1930s Edmund Samarakkody was associated with the working-class movement and Marxist politics in Sri Lanka, not merely during the forward sweep of its heyday, but importantly during its times of crisis and retreat. Adhering to the fundamental principles and practice of Marxism-Leninism, he participated to the end of his life in the working class led anti-capitalist struggle, for the overthrow of capitalism-imperialism and its replacement by an international socialist order.

Inspired in his youth by the tumultuous tramway strike in 1929, during which workers burned down the Maradana Police Station and law students with flags and red sashes demonstrated in sympathy with the strikers, Edmund sat down to write a leaflet entitled, "Students of Ceylon Arise." Urging the workers to fight he exhorted the students to give "up their splendour and come out to the streets and join the workers to save the destruction of civilisation and bring universal equality, happiness and prosperity."

A youthful cry indeed! Many an impressionable young man of his age might have been similarly inspired, even if they had not put down their feelings in so many words. How many nevertheless would have clung to their thoughts and developed them into maturity, over a span of 60 years?

In point of fact, most of the one-time stalwarts of the Left movement itself with whom Edmund had collaborated fell by the wayside, each in his own time, and succumbed to the established social order. Edmund is among the few who stood their ground. This would have been not surprising, if in the meantime the self-same issues that tormented society then had not developed into menacing proportions, both nationally and internationally. The fate of mankind is indeed more terrifying to contemplate today than it was in 1929.

As a Marxist-Leninist Edmund believed that the major problems of society, such as those of the working class, the peasantry and the oppressed and toiling masses and all forms of political and national oppression are inextricably bound up with the capitalist-imperialist world order, and that the path to their solution lay in its revolutionary overthrow through working-class struggle.

Without being merely a biographical narrative about Edmund Samarakkody, T. Perera's work serves as a welcome study to those readers interested particularly in the history of the left movement, the so-called "collapse of the left" and even "the death of communism." What had appeared to be a mass-based movement and a revolutionary Marxist party (the LSSP), making great strides in challenging the capitalist order in Sri Lanka, ended up becoming collaborators of the capitalist class, as co-partners in coalition with the SLFP, and being reduced to the position of servitors of the very same capitalist order against which they had been fighting.

Here the reader is taken back by the author to the momentous developments within the Marxist movement in the early 1940s. It is against the backdrop of the crisis of imperialism during World War II that the LSSP, formed in 1935, actually underwent a transformation in an attempt to forge itself into a revolutionary party and help build the BLPI (Bolshevik Leninist Party of India) of which the LSSP was to be its Sri Lankan section.

However, with the failure of the BLPI to utilize the momentous revolutionary possibilities opening up in 1942 in India, and the consequent emergence of a relatively settled national capitalist order under the Indian National Congress led by Gandhi, the BLPI itself broke up and immersed itself in the politics of the Congress.

The split in the local section of the BLPI itself into the reformist LSSP led by Philip and N.M. and the BSP (Bolshevik Samasamaja Party) led by the Colvin-Leslie group and the subsequent unprincipled re-unification of the two groups, as the LSSP, soon paved the way to the transformation

of the LSSP once again into a parliamentary reformist, social democratic party.

Although a Marxist tendency did emerge in the party subsequently and existed up to the 1960s, it was the reformists who managed to take over the party and the movement and eventually ended up in the coalition with the capitalist SLFP in the 1970s. Edmund all along worked within the Marxist tendency up to the split in 1964. In due course, however, with the acknowledged leadership of the revolutionary wing itself succumbing to the reformists, it was a largely a disparate section that split in 1964 to form the LSSP-R (Lanka Sama Samaja Party – Revolutionary).

Accordingly it was from 1964 onwards that Edmund's role in the Left movement begins to acquire greater significance. In Edmund's own view, as the author of the biography suggests, the crucial shift in the direction of parliamentary reformism had its origins in the late 1940s, and the coalition politics of the 1960s and 1970s were the eventual end result of that regressive process.

The role of the Marxist tendency and of Edmund himself in relation to the task of averting the rightward slide in the party from the 1940s onwards are problems that could be examined in further detail. T. Perera's book provides in particular a broad but valuable survey of the part that Edmund together

with his leftwing colleagues played in seeking to build once again a revolutionary party and movement in Sri Lanka.

As mentioned earlier, T. Perera's profile of Edmund is no run of the mill biographical narrative. Edmund's political life is here studied, as it necessarily has to be done, to render it meaningful in the context of a variety of issues affecting the international socialist movement. The author has endeavoured to do so within the ambit of a small book. He has also made use of published and unpublished material.

It might be said that it was the last twenty five years of Edmund's life that added stature and made him a more remarkable personality in the Marxist movement. He alone among the first generation leaders of the movement such as Philip, N.M., Colvin and Leslie had without succumbing to parliamentary reformism steadfastly adhered to the path of Marxism-Leninism.

In the words of his longtime comrade and collaborator Meryl Fernando in his introduction:

Edmund kept his faith in socialism. But he had to swim against the current in his attempt to build a viable political group in Sri Lanka, to help build a Trotskyist centre internationally. He remained in the arena of struggle till the end. ■

The writer was a member of the LSSP from the 1950s to the 1964 split and subsequently a member of the LSSP-R and Revolutionary Workers Party.

Available at the Suriya Bookshop

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THE EMERALD CITY AND THE RED FORT

Ram Manikkalingam

I read two books recently: *Imperial Life in the Emerald City: Inside Iraq's Green Zone* by Rajiv Chandrasekaran recounts experiences of the administration of Paul Bremer and the occupying forces in the Green Zone; and *The Last Mughal: the Fall of a Dynasty*, Delhi, 1857, by William Dalrymple, on the extraordinary story of the last Mughal emperor of India – Bahadur Shah Zafar – in the Red Fort. The disgusting and disturbing spectacle of Saddam Hussein's hanging and my chief editor Abbas Raza's constant pressure to name my favourite books of 2006 got me thinking about the curious coincidence that two among them link imperialism and evangelism, and recount the remaking of other societies.

Comparisons are odious, particularly between the tolerant, gentle and cultivated head of a great dying dynasty and the unsophisticated evangelical representatives of a declining superpower, although both were cocooned in their respective courts. The last Mughal built his own world of poetry, music, hunting, dancing and partying in the Red Fort. The Americans built theirs of BBQs, movie theatres, trailers, press conferences, bars and discos in the Emerald City.

Shah Zafar, a poet who understood his condition as a virtual prisoner of the British living out the end of a dynasty, wrote:

“Who ever enters this gloomy palace, Remains a prisoner for life in European captivity.”

Although an expert marksman, Zafar was no warrior. He patronized the poets, musicians and intellectuals of Delhi, and focused his energy and effort on the intellectual and cultural life of the city. He was tolerant towards all faiths: refusing to bow to the conservative imam's demand to change his doctor who converted to Christianity and wary of Muslims who insisted on converting Hindus or slaughtering cows to fulfill Islamic obligations. On non-religious occasions, Shah Zafar is known to have refrained from entering mosques, since he also could not enter temples. He was not very adroit at managing his complex and cumbersome harem of many wives and concubines. His “harem was notoriously lax as far as discipline and security were concerned.” And the

punishments he meted to his concubines who crossed the line were lenient, if administered at all.

The mutiny of 1857 took not just the British but also Shah Zafar by surprise. The Indian troops – Muslim and Hindu – rallied around him as the rightful ruler of India with the political objective of restoring the Mughal Empire. The pious old (he was 82 years at the time) Sufi poet Shah Zafar suddenly became the reluctant head of a rebel army that rallied to Delhi as the last seat of Mughal sovereignty. He vacillated, not because he was timorous or weak, but because he was torn among knowledge of imminent failure and duty towards the troops rebelling in his name, and a desire to protect his subjects, the Delhi dwellers caught in between two contending armies.

The rebellion had powerful religious overtones to it. The divide was as much between British rulers and Indians ruled, as Christian versus Hindu and Muslim. The rebellion struck a chord, because it was responding to an imperial shift away from a religiously tolerant, even assimilationist, form of British rule, to one that combined Christian evangelism with British power. British agents, who had once taken on Indian wives and ways, and even Muslim religion and Hindu rituals, refraining from eating pork and beef, now felt that they were there to remake native societies in their own image. The rebels spared Muslim Englishmen (yes, there were some in Delhi) but not Christian Indians. There were atrocities committed against English men and women trapped in Delhi. But all of this paled in comparison with British reprisals after the rebellion collapsed. British soldiers committed mass murder, rape and the wholesale destruction of one of the world's most beautiful cities. Palaces, mosques and madrasas were destroyed in a misguided effort to punish a city for the rebellion.

Shah Zafar was exiled to Rangoon shortly afterwards, and died there in 1862 at the age of 87. He led a sad and humiliating exile. And his chief wife and surviving sons were not allowed to return to India under British rule. Today, Shah Zafar's burial place is, fittingly for a man who loved poetry and was both religious and tolerant, a Sufi shrine where Muslims in Burma come to worship.

Imperial Life in the Emerald City describes a very different form of isolation—rulers choosing to set themselves apart from the ruled by building a bubble around themselves. The members of the occupying authority ate pork (served by Muslim workers), drank alcohol and touched not a morsel of food grown in Iraq within the green zone. The only contact with Iraqis were those who worked under them, and were therefore hesitant to criticize them, and Iraqi politicians dependent on the occupying authority for their power.

The rulers in the green zone demonstrated a remarkable lack of curiosity and interest in Iraqi history and politics. They believed that they had correctly conceived the new Iraq. And all that was required to execute this conception was the right combination of men, guns, dollars and cement. In their evangelizing zeal, they believed that Iraqi politicians and American soldiers who raised questions about how exactly to execute this conception of Iraq, or needing more men and dollars, were inadequate to the task at hand. As the going got tougher, the plans got fancier.

Efforts were made to privatize state industries running at a loss, lay off workers and secure foreign investors, at precisely the time when unemployment was the biggest challenge facing Iraqis, and no foreigners could travel to Baghdad to view their potential investments, let alone try to turn them around. Other plans that would have had a far-reaching impact on ordinary Iraqis included taking away rations of food in exchange for cash, at a time when transporting goods to the market, not the money to pay for them, was the key issue. More fanciful plans included giving debit cards to families to pay for food in a country where phone lines did not work because of regular losses of electrical power.

My favourite is the plan to have a state-of-the-art stock market, with the fanciest computers and the most squeaky clean transparency regulations to ensure that Iraq's stock market would be up and running, when all the Iraqis wanted was a large room with dry-erase boards. The young American advisor spent months and hundreds of thousands trying to get the stock market off the ground with his grandiose plans. Two days after he left Baghdad, the new Iraqi stock market opened successfully with white boards to write bids and chits of paper to note transactions. The American advisor expressed frustration at the lack of Iraqi cooperation. Still, he felt that if he had not done his job, maybe nothing would have happened at all. When asked what would have happened in the absence of the young American advisor, the Iraqi Chairman of the Stock Exchange responded that they would have opened months earlier. At precisely the moment when no American civilian members of the occupying authority could travel outside the green zone, the planning for the wholesale economic reconstruction of Iraq got more and more ambitious.

Like Shah Zafar who wrote his beautiful poetry and encouraged his court musicians to sing and intellectuals to write, because he knew he had no power outside the Red Fort, the rulers in the Emerald City were encouraged to formulate plans and promulgate laws they need not ever worry about implementing. But unlike Zafar in the Red Fort, these officials of the occupying authority were out of touch with reality. Zafar was a sad old man, who wrote poetry because he knew he had no power to do anything else. By contrast, the new rulers in Iraq were strutting around the Emerald City, spending more and more time drawing up grander and grander plans, without realizing that they were doing so at precisely the moment when they no longer had the ability or power to implement them. ■

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Kumudini Samuel's
Hidden History
women's activism for peace in Sri Lanka 1982-2002
available in English, Sinhala and Tamil
Price: Rs. 200/- each
at the Suriya Bookshop

IMAGINING KARMA

Premakumara de Silva

Imagining Karma : Ethical Transformation in Amerindian, Buddhist, and Greek Rebirth, by Gananath Obeyesekere, University of California Press.

Gananath Obeyesekere, professor emeritus of anthropology at Princeton University, is no doubt one of the world's greatest living anthropologists. The impressive genre of works he has produced over the years has earned him a canonical status within the discipline of anthropology. His recent work, *Cannibal Talk: The Man-Eating Myth and Human Sacrifice in the South Seas* (2005), solidifies this status. Obeyesekere's prior work *Imagining Karma* (2002), a study of the concept and practice of reincarnation, is one of the grandest theoretical labours that speaks to the theme rebirth from a broad cross-cultural perspective. It explores in rich detail the beliefs of small-scale societies of West Africa, Melanesia, Siberia, Canada and the northwest coast of North America, and compares their ideas with those of the ancient and modern Indic civilizations and with the Greek rebirth theories of Pythagoras, Empedocles, Pindar and Plato. This groundbreaking study shows that rebirth eschatologies are not unique to Indian religious tradition, as many Indologists and intellectuals assume, but are found scattered in other parts of the world. In his words:

My initial rationale for embarking on this project was to justify decentering India as the home and ground of rebirth. But I go beyond my Buddhist prejudice to a vision of a larger purpose: I explore the common fate of those societies that through historical accident or through the circulation of ideas or through independent invention...in reincarnation as an integral part of their larger eschatological and cosmological belief systems (2002:XV).

Obeyesekere demonstrates the process by which a simple rebirth eschatology is transformed into the Greek rebirth eschatology and the Buddhist karmic eschatology. As far as

small-scale societies are concerned there were no ethical or moral (good or bad behaviour sends one at death to heaven or hell) questions that determined one's rebirth. But in "civilized societies" 'ethicization' affects a person's destiny after death. Obeyesekere argues quite convincingly that when ethicization is systematically introduced into any rebirth eschatology the latter must logically transform itself into a "karmic eschatology." Once reborn into a world where an ethicized morality already exists, the individual must perforce continue in his life trajectory doing good or bad, acquiring sin and merit. In such world kinship affiliation no longer determines who goes where after death but moral action does. In religions like Buddhism animals get demoted in such a way that human beings who do wrong or commit sin might be punished with rebirth as an animal or other lower form of being. Here, Obeyesekere gives considerable attention to elaborate relation between reincarnation in animals and vegetarianism.

There are seven long chapters in the book. The first chapter discusses the logic of karmic eschatology and rebirth in Indic religions, and the second chapter provides the comprehensive account of non-indic theories of rebirth. Chapter three presents a detailed analysis of the transformation of the rebirth eschatology and the emergence of the karmic eschatology. Chapters four and five, respectively, give brilliant accounts of Buddhist and Greek eschatologies of rebirth and karma. Chapter six explores the Greek rebirth theories and discusses the idea of God in relation to soul. The final chapter opens up debates on Trobriander, Buddhist and Balinese rebirth and raises important methodological issues in comparative studies.

This provocative work deals with the most fundamental questions of human existence and challenges us to reexamine the accepted ideas about death, cosmology and eschatology. One book blurb says, a few scholars would attempt this kind, of a project today, but Obeyesekere does it quite brilliantly.

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